

Observation

EES 4760/5760

Agent-Based and Individual-Based Computational Modeling

J. Magnolia Gilligan

Class #10: Tuesday, September 29, 2026



Announcements

Announcements

- Classes canceled Tues Oct. 6 and Thurs. Oct. 8
- Makeup classes:
 - Monday Oct. 5, 4:15–5:30, SC 5737 (Jewell Conference Room)
 - Monday Oct. 12, 4:15–5:30, SC 5737 (Jewell Conference Room)

Observation

Observation

The **observation** design concept is about what you (the scientist) want to observe about your model to help answer your research question.

Some ways to observe your model include:

- The model view on the interface
- Monitors on the interface
- Agent-monitors (`inspect turtle`, `inspect patch`, `watch turtle`, `follow turtle`)
- Set patch or turtle labels (`set label elevation` or `set plabel count turtles-here`)
- Set patch or turtle color (`set color blue` or `set pcolor green`)
- Set turtle shape or size (`set shape "butterfly"`, `set size 4`)
- Plots and histograms on the interface
- Output to output window, command center, or file:
 - `print`, `show`, `type`, `write`
 - `file-print`, `file-show`, `file-type`, `file-write`
 - `output-print`, `output-show`, `output-type`, `output-write`
- BehaviorSpace experiments

Observing the Butterfly Model

- Download butterfly model

https://ees4760.jmgilligan.org/models/class_10/butterfly_class_10.nlogox

and elevation file

https://ees4760.jmgilligan.org/models/class_10/ElevationData.txt,

save them in the same folder, and open the butterfly model in NetLogo.

- Go to the code tab and look at `update-display` and `color-patches`

Observations in the View

Observations in the View

- Go to `move` and change

```
ifelse random-float 1 < q
[
  uphill elevation ; Move uphill
]
[
  move-to one-of neighbors ; Otherwise move randomly
]
```

to

```
ifelse random-float 1 < q
[
  uphill elevation          ; Move uphill
  set color red              ; Set to red to indicate uphill
]
[
  move-to one-of neighbors ; Otherwise move randomly
  set color blue           ; Set to blue to indicate random movement
]
```

Observations in the View

- Edit `crt` in `setup`:

```
set label-color pink
```

- Edit `update-display`:

```
to update-display
  color-patches
  ifelse show-butterflies?
    [ask turtles [show-turtle]]
    [ask turtles [hide-turtle]]
  ifelse show-labels?
    [ask turtles [set label
                    precision elevation 1 ]]
    [ask turtles [set label ""]]
end
```

- Set `num-butterflies` to 1 or 5, press `setup`, and run the model

- When you set `label` or `plabel` to a variable:
 - It gets the current value of the variable.
 - It won't update automatically.
 - You have to set it to the new value
 - e.g., Update `label` in `update-display`, and call `update-display` every tick
 - Remove a label by setting it to an empty text string (" ")

Observations in the View

- Edit `color-patches`:

```
to color-patches
  ifelse patch-coloring = "elevation"
  [
    let max-elevation max [elevation] of patches
    let min-elevation min [elevation] of patches
    ask patches [ set pcolor scale-color green elevation
                    min-elevation max-elevation]
  ]
  [
    let max-turtles max [count turtles-here] of patches
    let min-turtles 0
    ask patches [ set pcolor scale-color cyan
                    (count turtles-here)
                    min-turtles max-turtles]
  ]
end
```

- Turn off `show-labels?` and `show-butterflies?` and set `num-butterflies` to 50
- Setup and run the model
- Adjust display:
 - Clear the paths,
 - Turn `show-butterflies?` off,
 - Press `update-display`

Adding monitors

Adding monitors

- Write a new reporter:

```
to-report fraction-crowded
  let crowd-count sum [count turtles in-radius 1.5] of patches with
    [count turtles in-radius 1.5 >= 4]
  report crowd-count / num-butterflies
end
```

- Add 3 monitors to the interface:

- **Mean elevation** gets reporter

```
mean [elevation] of turtles
```

- **Mean turtles** gets reporter

```
mean [count turtles-here] of patches with [any? turtles-here]
```

- **Fraction crowded** gets reporter

```
fraction-crowded
```

Monitoring agents

- Set `num-butterflies` to 6 and setup.
- Right click your mouse **near** a *turtle* and choose “Inspect Patch”
- In the patch-inspect window, right click on a turtle and choose “Inspect Turtle #”
- In the turtle window, click “Watch”
- Click “step” a few times or let the model “go” for a while
- Close the monitoring windows
- Right click on the world and choose “Reset perspective”
- Right click on a turtle and choose “Turtle #/Follow turtle #”
- Click “step” several times, or “go”
- Setup the model again
- Type `inspect turtle 5` at the observer line.
- Type `watch turtle 3` at the observer line.

Plots and Histograms

Adding plots and histograms

- Add three plots:

1. Patch density:

- Edit default pen: set mode to "Bar"
- Set update command to `histogram [count turtles-here] of patches`
- Set X min = 1, X max = 20, Y min = 0, Y max = 10
- Set X label to "Turtles per patch", Y label to "count"

2. Fraction crowded:

- Set plot command to `plot 100 * fraction-crowded`
- Set Y min = 0, Y max = 100
- Set X label to "Tick", Y label to "Percent"

3. Mean elevation:

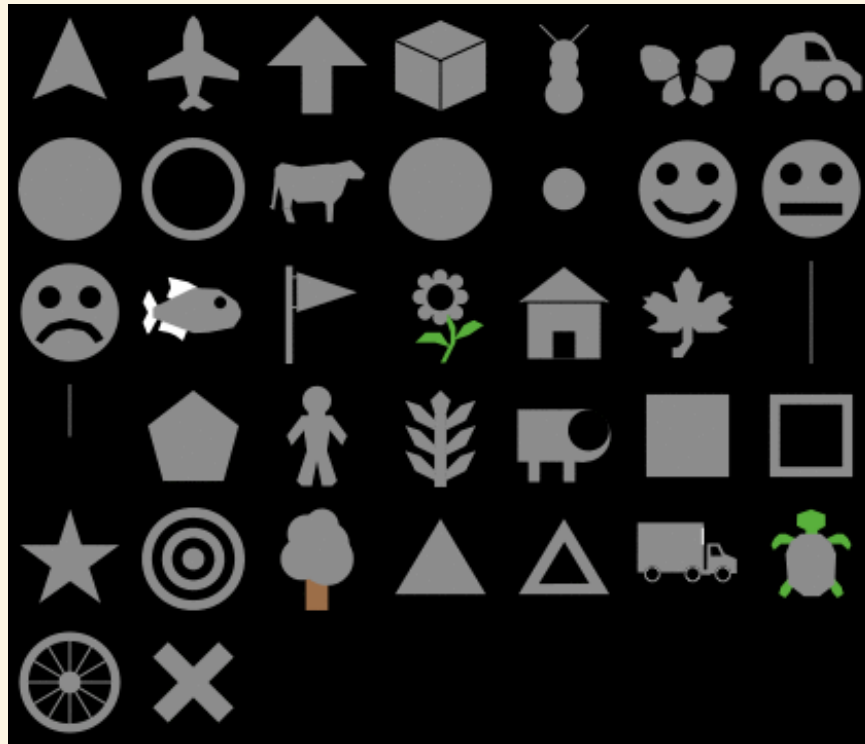
- Set plot command to `plot mean [elevation] of turtles`
- Set Y min = 500, Y max = 500
- Set X label to "Tick", Y label to "Elevation"

- Set num-butterflies to 50 and run the model.

Size and Shape

Setting turtle size and shape

- Turtle shapes:



- See [Shapes Editor](#) in the NetLogo manual for details

```
ask turtles [set shape "butterfly"]
```

File output

File output

- First open file (generally, check whether a file exists, and delete it).

```
if (file-exists? "my_test_output.csv")
[
  carefully                ; Try the first block of code.
                          ; If there's an error execute the second
  [ file-delete "my_test_output.csv" ]
  [ print error-message ] ; error-message is a primitive
]
file-open "my_test_output.csv"
```

- It's also a good idea to write a header with the names of the columns.

```
file-type "id,"           ; file-type prints to file without ending the line
file-type "tick,"
file-print "elevation"    ; file-print prints to file and ends the line
```

- Then at each tick, you could write data:

```
file-open "my_test_output.csv"
ask turtles [
  ; turtle #, ticks, elevation on each line
  file-type word who ","
  file-type word ticks ","
  file-print elevation
]
```

Closing files

- When the model stops, you need to close the file.

```
to go
...
if ticks > 500
[
  file-close-all
  stop
]
```

Multiple file output

You can have multiple files open at once. Switch between them using `file-open`.

```
file-open "turtle_output.csv"
ask turtles [
  file-type word who ","
  file-type word ticks ","
  file-print elevation
]

file-open "summary_output.csv"
file-type word ticks ","
file-type word (mean [elevation] of turtles) ","
file-print 100 * fraction-crowded
```

Exporting to files

- If you have plots, you can output the data from the plot to a file using `export-plot`

```
export-plot "Fraction crowded" "frac_crowded.csv"
```

- You can export the current state of your entire model (all turtles, patches, their turtles-own, patches-own variables, etc.) using `export-world`
 - You can import the world to restart your model where you left off using `import-world`
- You can also export plots, world, etc. from the “File/Export” menu.

Model with Observations

Model with Observations

You can download the full model with different observations we have been discussing at

https://ees4760.jmgilligan.org/models/class_10/butterfly_class_10_observing.r